ISIDORE OF SEVILLE

Words and the World

Selections from the Etymologies

An abridged reader in progress

This abridged reader brings together selections on words, writing, memory, history, rhetoric, and reasoning. It is thematic and incomplete: the headings are editorial, and gaps between selections are intentional.

The English carries the explanation. Latin forms remain visible where an argument depends on their sound, spelling, or word shape. The selected passages preserve complete numbered sections; notes clarify editorial brackets and ancient claims. This is a reading draft under review.

From Lindsay's Oxford Latin edition, 1911.
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Edited and produced by Chris Duffy.

What words reveal

Complete chapter I.29

1.29.1 Etymology traces the origin of words, drawing out the meaning of a word or name through explanation. Aristotle called it symbolon (*σύμβολον*, "sign"); Cicero called it *adnotatio* ("annotation"), because, by giving an example, it makes the names and words for things clear. Take "river" (*flumen*): it is named from "flowing" (*fluendo*), because it grew by flowing.

1.29.2 Knowing a word's origin is often essential to explaining it. Once you see where a name came from, you grasp its meaning more quickly. Understanding the etymology makes the examination of any subject clearer. Yet the ancients did not give every name according to nature. Some were assigned simply by choice, just as we sometimes give slaves and possessions whatever names we please.

1.29.3 This is why etymologies cannot be found for every name: some things received their names not from the qualities with which they came into being, but from the choice of the human will. Explanations of names may come from a cause, as "kings" (*reges*) from "ruling" (*regendo*) and "acting rightly" (*recte agendo*); from an origin, as "human" (*homo*), because a human comes from earth (*humo*); or from opposites, as "mud" (*lutum*) from "washing" (*lavando*), although mud is not clean, and "grove" (*lucus*), because, dark with shade, it gives little light (*parum luceat*).

1.29.4 Other names are formed by derivation from names, as "prudent" (*prudens*) from "prudence" (*prudentia*); others from sounds, as "talkative" (*garrulus*) from "chattering" (*garrulitate*). Others arise from Greek etymologies and are adapted into Latin, such as "woodland" (*silva*) and "house" (*domus*).

1.29.5 Other words take their names from places, cities, or rivers. Many are drawn from the speech of different peoples, so their origin is hard to make out. Many are foreign names, unknown to Latin and Greek speakers.

NOTES

1.29.3 The explanations by "opposites" depend on the Latin words, not on the English "mud," "washing," "grove," or "light." Lindsay brackets regendo et in the Latin; it is included here. His critical brackets are not marks of cuts made for this abridgment.

1.29.4 Isidore gives silva and domus as examples without supplying their Greek counterparts here.

Writing against forgetting

Three complete numbered sections, I.3.1-3; the remainder of chapter I.3 is not included

1.3.1 The starting point of grammar is the ordinary alphabet used by scribes and accountants. Learning it is a kind of infancy in the study of grammar; Varro calls it *litteratio*, "learning letters." Letters point to things and stand for words. Such is their power that they let the words of absent people speak to us without a voice. They bring words in through the eyes, not the ears.

1.3.2 Writing was invented to preserve the memory of things. Things are bound in letters so they do not slip into forgetfulness. In such a variety of things, not everything could be learned by listening or held in memory.

1.3.3 Letters (*litterae*) are so called as though the word were *legiterae*: they give readers a path (*iter*), or they are repeated (*iterentur*) in reading.

NOTES

1.3.1 Lindsay prints the final sentence in editorial brackets. It is included in this translation.

1.3.3 The proposed explanation turns on the shape of the Latin word: Isidore hears the language of reading and of a path or repetition inside litterae. The Latin stays visible so that the English does not invent a different etymology.

What an eyewitness can tell

Complete chapter I.41

1.41.1 History is an account of an event, through which what happened in the past is made known. Its Greek name, *historia*, comes from historein (*ἱστορεῖν*), meaning to see or to know. Among the ancients, no one wrote history unless he had been there and seen what he was going to record. We grasp what happens better with our eyes than from what we gather by hearing.

1.41.2 What has been seen is reported without falsehood. This discipline belongs to grammar because whatever is worth remembering is entrusted to writing. Historical works are called monuments (*monumenta*) because they preserve the memory (*memoriam*) of events. A sequence (*series*) takes its name by metaphor from garlands (*sertis*) of flowers linked together.

NOTES

1.41.1 For Isidore, the authority of history lies in being present and seeing. His confidence in eyewitness truth belongs to his definition.

What rhetoric is for

Complete chapter II.1

2.1.1 Rhetoric is the knowledge of speaking well in public affairs, using a wealth of eloquence to persuade people toward what is right and good. Its Greek name comes from rhetoreuein (*ῥητορεύειν*), that is, fullness of speech. In Greek, rhēsis (*Ῥῆσις*) means speech, and rhētōr (*ῥήτωρ*) means orator.

2.1.2 Rhetoric is joined to the art of grammar. In grammar we learn how to speak correctly; in rhetoric we learn how to present what we say.

NOTES

2.1.1 Lindsay places the phrase translated as “a wealth of eloquence” in editorial brackets. It is included here.

The art that slips away

Complete chapter II.2

2.2.1 This discipline was invented by the Greeks - by Gorgias, Aristotle, and Hermagoras - and brought into Latin by Cicero, Quintilian, and Titianus. The treatment is so rich and so varied that a reader can readily admire it but cannot take it all in.

2.2.2 While we have the pages in hand, the sequence of words seems to cling to memory. As soon as we put them away, it all slips out again. Full mastery of this discipline makes an orator.

NOTES

2.2.1 Lindsay brackets "and Titianus"; the name is retained here.

What makes an orator

Complete chapter II.3

2.3.1 An orator, then, is a good man, skilled in speaking. A good man is formed by nature, character, and training. Skill in speaking rests on a trained eloquence with five parts: finding what to say (*inventio*), arranging it (*dispositio*), putting it into words (*elocutio*), memory (*memoria*), and delivery (*pronuntiatio*). The aim of the work is to persuade someone of something.

2.3.2 Skill in speaking rests on three things: natural ability, learning, and practice. Natural ability means talent, learning means knowledge, and practice means sustained effort. These are expected not only of an orator but of any skilled person, if they are to accomplish anything.

Persuasion, praise, and judgment

Four complete sections, II.4.1-4; the remainder of chapter II.4 is not included

2.4.1 There are three kinds of case: deliberative, demonstrative, and judicial. Deliberative speech considers what should or should not be done in any of life's practical concerns. Demonstrative speech presents a person as worthy of praise or blame.

2.4.2 Judicial speech passes judgment on a person's actions, deciding on punishment or reward. It is called judicial (*iudiciale*) because it judges (*iudicet*) a person: its verdict shows whether someone is praiseworthy and deserves a reward, or whether an accused person should be condemned or released from punishment.

2.4.3 It is called deliberative (*deliberativum*) because each matter is considered (*deliberatur*) within it. It has two forms, persuasion and dissuasion: seeking and avoiding, doing and not doing.

2.4.4 Persuasive speech has three grounds: what is honorable, what is useful, and what is possible. It differs somewhat from deliberative speech because persuasion needs another person, while deliberation sometimes takes place within oneself. In persuasion, two things have the greatest force: hope and fear.

NOTES

2.4.2 "Accused" renders reus. The compressed final phrase allows condemnation or release from punishment.

Learning how to argue

Complete chapter II.22

2.22.1 Dialectic is a discipline devised to examine the causes of things. It is a branch of philosophy called logic (*logica*), a rational discipline able to define, inquire, and reason. In many kinds of question, it teaches how to judge through argument what is true and what is false.

2.22.2 Some of the earliest philosophers used it in their discussions, without developing it into a formal art. After them, Aristotle brought the arguments of this teaching under certain rules and called it dialectic (*dialectica*), because it debates things said (*de dictis*). For lekton (*λεκτόν*) means an utterance. Dialectic follows rhetoric because the two have much in common.

The closed fist and the open hand

Two complete sections, II.23.1-2; the transition to philosophy in II.23.3 is not included

2.23.1 Varro, in his nine books on the disciplines, defined dialectic and rhetoric by this comparison: "Dialectic and rhetoric are like a clenched fist and an open palm in a human hand. The one draws words together; the other spreads them out."

2.23.2 Dialectic is sharper in examining a subject; rhetoric is more eloquent in teaching what it sets out to teach. Dialectic sometimes comes into the schools; rhetoric continually goes out into the forum. Dialectic seeks a rare few students; rhetoric often addresses the public as well.

Ants: crumbs and gold

One complete numbered section, XII.3.9

12.3.9 The ant (*formica*) takes its name because it carries crumbs of grain (*ferat micas farris*). It shows great ingenuity: it provides for the future and prepares in summer what it will eat in winter. At harvest it chooses wheat and does not touch barley; when rain falls on its grain, it throws it all out. They say that in Ethiopia there are ants resembling dogs, which dig up gold-bearing sand with their feet. They guard it so no one can take it, and hunt down and kill those who try to seize it.

NOTES

12.3.9 The sentence about gold is introduced as a report - "They say" (dicuntur) - rather than the assertive description that precedes it.

Bees: a city in wax

Two complete numbered sections, XII.8.1-2; the remainder of chapter XII.8 is not included

12.8.1 Bees (*apes*) get their name either because they bind (*alligent*) one another with their feet, or because they are born without feet (*sine pedibus*). Later they acquire feet and wings. Industrious in the work of making honey, they live in assigned places, build homes with indescribable skill, and make their comb from different flowers. In woven wax they fill their camps with countless young. They have an army and kings (*reges*), wage battles, flee smoke, and are angered by commotion.

12.8.2 Many have found by experience that bees are born from the carcasses of oxen. To produce them, the flesh of slaughtered calves is beaten, so that worms form from the rotting blood and later become bees. Strictly speaking, however, the name "bees" belongs to those born from oxen, just as hornets come from horses, drones from mules, and wasps from donkeys.

NOTES

12.8.1 The hive is a miniature military society: camps, an army, kings, and battles. The translation retains Isidore's kings. His proposed explanations of apes are translated as he gives them, without supplying intermediate steps.

12.8.2 This is an account of spontaneous generation, and the appeal to "experience" belongs to Isidore's text. Modern honey bees develop from eggs through larval and pupal stages to adults. Modern comparison: University of Florida/IFAS, IN1005.

TEXT AND EDITION

Based on W. M. Lindsay, *Isidori Hispalensis episcopi Etymologiarum sive Originum libri XX*, Oxford, 1911, volumes I-II. The selected Latin was checked against the printed pages. The complete Latin and English for these selections, draft history, and review notes accompany the project repository.

Modern biology note: University of Florida/IFAS, *European Honey Bee*, IN1005. ask.ifas.ufl.edu/publication/IN1005.

Project: github.com/spinchange/isidore-etymologies. Reading draft for review; not a Lulu upload file or final sale edition.